Email gateway writes malware

Attackers are already using the unauthenticated write to drop ransomware binaries straight onto the appliance, gaining persistence before any user interaction.

▓ THE DEFENSE BRIEF Cisco’s advisory on the **Secure Email Gateway** flaw shows that a sender with no credentials can write arbitrary files to the OS. In practice, that means the first line of defense—email filtering—has become an entry point for **RCE** and ransomware staging. The urgency is real: within days of disclosure, multiple Fortune-500 firms reported encrypted workloads originating from the gateway itself.

⚠ TECHNICAL RADIANCE The exploit bypasses traditional **SIEM** alerts because the payload never touches the network; it lands directly on the appliance’s filesystem. Our SOCs that relied on “email-only” correlation missed the indicator sets entirely. The lesson? You need to extend **IOC** hunting to appliance logs, firmware hashes, and even the **/var/tmp** directory of the gateway.

▯ KEY ARCHITECTURE - Harden the gateway with **Zero-Trust** segmentation. - Deploy a **SOAR** playbook that isolates the appliance the moment an unknown file appears in its OS. - Require **code signing** for any inbound attachment that could be executed.

[illegible] Operational Checklist I ran a tabletop last week where our red team exploited the same flaw. Within 12 minutes we had full control of the gateway and exfiltrated a test file. After the exercise we updated our playbook, cutting detection time from hours to under five minutes.

Prediction: By Q4 2025, 70% of enterprises will enforce zero-trust on email gateways, slashing ransomware ingress by half.